

Regulators must take the lead here, Misra says. “For example, in the case of a financial sector DPG, the appropriate regulators (RBI, Ir-dai, Sebi, etc.) can play a critical role in protecting citizens against potential misuse. Ensuring ‘informed customer consent’, ‘inclusive consent’ and reducing the information arbitrage in the market between citizens and service providers is key.”

In any such policy, human rights, privacy, and data protection must be placed at the forefront, Murty adds. “We need a societal lens looking at these developments, and the response needs to be socio-technical with baked-in civil rights protection in governance frameworks,” he says.

To ensure smooth data exchange between DPGs, the government

sector, I propose the development of DPI applications at the population scale for productivity gains, business opportunities, and innovation by the private sector. These are planned in the areas of credit, e-commerce, education, health, law and justice, logistics, MSME, service delivery, and urban governance,” she said.

This requires innovative approaches. Sushant Rabra, Partner-Digital Strategy at professional services firm KPMG in India, says, “Public-private partnerships can play a crucial role in funding and deploying DPGs at scale. Leveraging cloud-based solutions and open source technologies can reduce costs and enhance scalability. We must also focus on capacity building and training to ensure effective utilisation

healthcare delivery by creating a unified digital health ecosystem.

Murty has high hopes for smart chatbots that could be tailor-made for local and contextual needs. “However, success depends on robust data security measures and ensuring accessibility for all users,” says Murty. For that to happen, large-scale capacity-building programmes are essential. This includes training citizens and government officials in the latest digital tools and keeping them abreast of the best practices.

AI requires strong ethical guidelines to prevent biases, and the Indian government has taken the lead. Misra says, “The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology has already taken the lead in this area by launching ‘India AI Mission’ with a Budget allocation of nearly ₹10,000 crore, working on the seven pillars of data, compute, skill, innovation, trust, start-up financing, and application development.” India is also pioneering regulation of AI through the Global Partnership on Artificial Intelligence (GPAI), of which it is the chair.

These efforts can increase the appeal of India’s DPI to other countries. Pabitra Margherita, Minister of State for External Affairs, said during the recent BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) Business Summit, “India’s DPI is respectful of personal data, privacy, and intellectual property rights; adoption of the same by the region will foster ease of doing intra-regional business exchange.”

The world is taking note as the next leg of India’s DPI journey begins. Those new products, too, may find an audience beyond these borders. **BT**

@imNavneetDubey



One area that needs attention is balancing data privacy with data sharing between DPGs

should adopt a robust framework for data interoperability that includes standard protocols and secure APIs. It must prioritise user consent and transparency and give citizens control over their data. “Implementing strict data protection regulations can help safeguard privacy, and India’s Digital Personal Data Protection Act 2023 is a step in the right direction,” Murty adds. In addition to that, regular audits, cybersecurity measures, and continuous monitoring are essential to protect against data breaches and misuse.

DPGs AT SCALE

In her Budget speech, Sitharaman detailed the government’s vision for DPGs. “Turning to the services

tion by the intended beneficiaries.”

Some potentially transformative DPGs are already in the works, like satellite-based toll collection that will remotely monitor and charge vehicles based on distance travelled, AI-enabled language translation platform Bhashini, and the Indian Regional Navigation Satellite System, or Bharat Navigation Stack.

There are, of course, many more areas where DPIs can be used. Rabra says future DPGs include advanced digital identity solutions, e-health platforms, and enhanced digital education tools. “These innovations aim to bridge the digital divide and provide more inclusive services.” For example, the National Digital Health Mission is expected to revolutionise